settle merely for the U.S. and the Western approach to governance and existing institutional arrangements.[94] Others, such as David Shambaugh, emphasize a domestic split in views of what China really wants.[95]

In sum, reasonable observers may disagree about the true mix of Chinese motivations for its collective financial statecraft. Different factors could lead China to become either a fully developed revisionist power or a status quo (but reformist) power in global financial governance. On the one hand, there are ample contemporary opportunities for China to challenge existing global financial governance fundamentally from a strong push to RMB internationalization to defense of capital controls. Illustrating a similar problem, David Dollar quotes an Indian official, exasperated at the pace of World Bank–sponsored projects, as saying: "Mr. Dollar, the combination of our bureaucracy and your bureaucracy is deadly."[96] Some parts of the AIIB and NDB governance structure (such as the absence of resident EDs who would decide on every funding project) have learned from the "negative examples" of the World Bank and the IMF.[97]

On the other hand, the costs of China asserting its regional financial power, let alone fundamentally changing the existing global financial system, could be considerable. Chinese leaders are sensitive to global market pressures and the country's global/institutional reputation. China is aware that the international spotlights are now on many of its initiatives, so they must look legitimate and not significantly tainted by corruption. The Chinese leadership and its reformers have already learned that it is necessary to use U.S./Western expertise in Bretton Woods institutions to the extent that they have resorted to Western consulting firms to write the articles for the NDB Charter. Like other powers, they still must adapt to markets.

As discussed previously, the BRICS club has been very useful for China to voice its aversions and frustrations, challenge Western/U.S. dominance in the global financial governance system, and air its views without destroying the very system from which China has long benefited. At the same time, China is not only hedging its bets, but also building and bolstering alternative forums by creating multiple layers of outside options, from the BRICS itself to NDB, RMB, and AIIB, because the Chinese authorities recognize that there are limits to how far inside reforms of the Bretton Woods institutions can go.[98]